

An Older Autistic Adult in Your Gentle-Activity Group

For walking-group, bowls, chair-exercise & gentle-activity leaders — supporting an older autistic adult (roughly 60+).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means an older adult's attention has always locked into a few deep, intense "tunnels." Gentle, structured activity is genuinely protective for older autistic adults — who are often physically inactive and socially isolated — and your group can be a lifeline. Many were never identified and may simply be "the quiet, routine-loving one." Predictability, low sensory load, a defined pace and welcome for a special interest turn a daunting group into a steady, confidence-building anchor.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Same spot, same pace, same route every week	Predictability and routine are regulation , not inflexibility
Quiet; deep knowledge of one topic	Lifelong special interest — welcome it
Drops out of noisy or changing sessions	Sensory/social overload, or hearing/vision strain
Slow to answer; asks you to repeat	Processing time + possible hearing loss — not confusion
Takes things literally; misses banter	Literal, single-channel communication

Try this

- **Keep the format predictable** — same time, route, partners, pace; warn before any change.
- **Lower the load** — quieter venues, good lighting, smaller groups; account for hearing/vision loss.
- **Give instructions in writing, one at a time**, with ample processing time.
- **Welcome the special interest and expertise** — let them lead a turn or share knowledge.
- **Offer low-pressure belonging** — a defined role, a familiar partner, no forced mixing.

Avoid this

- Surprise route/activity changes, loud group games, or "spontaneous" social demands.
- Assuming slowness or a different style means decline or incapacity.
- Disrupting their familiar spot or routine "for variety."

When to get more support

Be alert to **social isolation** and gently signpost community and autism-led connection. If you notice a real change in ability or engagement, share it supportively — distinguishing lifelong autistic difference from decline needs careful assessment, not assumption.

If the person is a woman

Older autistic women are especially under-identified, having masked for a lifetime; “quiet and anxious” may be unrecognised autism.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — the **Family guide** (Part 5), **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 4) and the **Monotropism** brief, with the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Part 3.5). Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool**. Old-age evidence is thin; fit it to the individual.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Klein et al. (2024, aging & autism); Michaud & Harvey (2025). Full citations are in the source drafts.